feed and protect abandoned cows. The money is generated from a 20 per cent cow cess, introduced in 2017-2018, that's levied on stamp papers and liquor. It's not inconsiderable, therefore. The state collected Rs 2,661 crore from the cess in 2023-2025—Rs 2,339 crore of that was spent for cow conservation. Just in 2023-24, the entire collection of Rs 1,227 crore was transferred for this ethico-religious project.

Eligible *gaushala*s get Rs 40 a day for an adult animal and Rs 20 for a calf. Naturally, that makes the cattle count each *gaushala* reports the basis of its grant. The CAG now says the numbers may have been inflated in dozens of cases. Its latest compliance audit report—for FY24, tabled in the assembly on August 21—says 38 *gaushala*s had cumulatively reported 131,000 head of cattle that could not be verified on the ground through shelter registers, animal-tag records, inspections and government databases.

Takeaways

- **CAG audit for FY24 finds 131,000 'ghost cows' on the records. Grants eaten up: Rs 57.36 crore**
- **Rajasthan has 2,800 *gaushala*s; 38 in the dock for over-reporting cows so as to pocket subsidy**
- ***Gaushala*s are paid Rs 40 for an adult animal, Rs 20 for a calf. Money comes from 'cow cess'**

DEAD OR MISSING

This may not prove that 131,000 phantom cows roamed through the state exchequer's pasture lands. But the audit found gaps between the daily registers maintained by *gaushala*s and the data recorded on the central Bharat Pashudhan app: the 'cow Aadhar' under the National Digital Livestock Mission. Also, invalid, inactive or unregistered ear tags. In some cases, grants were claimed for cattle that had died, been moved elsewhere or were not found in the shelter during the period for which assistance was sought. Under rules set in 2023, the entire system is supposed to be monitored through ear tags, registers noting deaths, sales, donations and transfers, besides surprise inspections.

Three months before the report, the Directorate had already issued recovery notices to the 38 *gaushala*s. No recovery has yet been made, though the notices are not the final word: the audit findings, too, are to be examined by departments and the assembly before the government decides how much, if any, is ultimately recoverable. "The issue will be taken to its logical end. We will improve the system," says Vikas Sitaramji Bhale, principal secretary, animal husbandry. The largest amounts flagged include Rs 16.36 crore at the Shri Braj Kamad Surabhi Van Research Institute Gaushala in Deeg and Rs 10.95 crore at the Shri Gopal Govardhan Gaushala in Pathmeda, Jalore. Pinjrapole Gaushala in Sanganer was flagged for about Rs 1.81 crore.

In August, acting on a PIL that alleged financial irregularities, neglect of cattle and environmental violations, the Rajasthan High Court, too, had issued notices to Pinjrapole Gaushala. In a 2025 ruling, it had upheld recovery notices to some gaushalas. In all, the state has over 2,800 cow shelters. Operators deny they are fraudulently milking the system, and cite administrative failures related to record-keeping and tagging. Meanwhile, Rajasthan has no dearth of real street cows. ■



By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IF THE OPPOSITION IS MIRED IN EXISTENTIAL CRISES, the burden of keeping a conflictual air alive within Maharashtra politics is borne well by the ruling Mahayuti. The running duel is between the dominant force, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), and the ambitious deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde's Shiv Sena, which is seeking to emerge as a force with a distinct imprimatur. Three episodes have brought this into sharp relief yet again: the Sena is staking claim to the Mumbai mayor's post, it has joined the fray in elections to one of the city's most prestigious cooperative banks, and it's raising the ante on a language controversy.

While the first two are pure play for power, it's the third that gives its jockeying for political space a more cultural-ideological flavour—strongly reminiscent of the old Shiv Sena's nativist politics from the Bal Thackeray era. In